

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Star-studded Silence



When Aparna Sen and Rituparno Ghosh spoke up against the Left Front Government in West Bengal, they were setting the gold standard for Bollywood's current inhabitants. Unlike their Hollywood counterparts, Bollywood superstars tend neither to have a philosophy nor philanthropy. Ask them to promote their movies, and they will talk non-stop, whether it is discussing their muscles or their dance moves. But ask them where Darfur is and they are likely to confuse it with a new luxury brand George Clooney endorses. Oh sure, there are occasional lapses from such complete self-absorption. Aamir Khan, for instance, can rue the condition of Narmada Dam refugees, Shah Rukh Khan can hold forth on America's war on Islam, and Preity Zinta can go on about the girl child. And the triptych of manufactured dissent, Javed Akhtar, Shabana Azmi and Mahesh Bhatt don't count, because their causes are as universal as their opinions.

But take the cameras away, switch off the microphones and the public posturing becomes just that.

Hey, this is not to say that every actor has to be an Angelina Jolie, putting her money (\$6 million of it to UNHCR and charitable organisations) where her heart is, or a Sean Penn, taking on his President on Iraq or saving victims of Hurricane Katrina. But in between promoting themselves, Bollywood stars could occasionally also use their vast



SAURABH SINGH

popularity to highlight causes. No, I don't mean the cause of Uttar Pradesh's erstwhile Mulayam Singh Yadav government, whose crime rate found an unfortunate champion in Amitabh Bachchan. Neither do I mean social service messages about polio drops, rural health check-ups and AIDS awareness, laudable though such time given freely to television advertisements may be.

I mean the issues that a democracy is faced with on a daily basis. Our stars are educated, well-read and acutely aware. Do they have no view on the riots in Gujarat, female infanticide or corruption? Views that can guide and inspire? Yes we know most of them—especially Bollywood bad boy Salman Khan—donate to charity and like to keep it quiet. But occasionally like Dev Anand or Nargis, we would like them to lead. And not only from the comfort zone of a newspaper campaign. Could it be that they fear retribution, the kind handed out to Aamir Khan in Gujarat on *Fanaa*? Could it be that we are intolerant of entertainer activism?

SIPRA DAS



MIFFED:
Janardhana Reddy

Fear and Security

HYDERABAD With Naxal violence on the rise everywhere in the country, those on the hit list are getting jittery by the day and want their security to be beefed up. The clamour for obtrusive Sten gun-toting personal security officers is passe and politicians now want full-fledged security ring around themselves.

Having survived two attempts on his life by Naxalites, former Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu is miffed by the fact that additional security has not been provided to him. He wants the arrangements to be upgraded on par with Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy or, at least to that provided to TDP chief N. Chandrababu Naidu. Naidu too had survived an attempt on his life by the Left wing extremists when he was chief minister.

"Compared to Naidu my security is pretty bad. Like him, I am also a former chief minister on the hit list of the Naxalites.

This is a painful situation. I have to beg shamelessly for scaling up my security. There should be no discrimination in providing security," laments Reddy, who had a narrow escape when a landmine was triggered off as his convoy whizzed by on September 7 in his native Nellore district. The blast claimed three lives.

Ironically, it was Reddy who as chief minister had declared the Naxalites as outlaws and banned their activities way back in 1991. He is particularly unhappy that Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil has not responded positively to his requests. Evidently, he wants the cover provided by the Black Cats of the National Security Guard as well as a fleet of bullet-proof cars including one equipped with an electronic jammer, similar to that extended to Naidu. Now, he has just one used car that was earlier allotted to Naidu who, on the other hand, is to get a fresh fleet of six bullet-proof cars soon.

by Amarnath K. Menon